

UNDERSTANDING THE BASICS: NATURE AND NURTURE

Carl Jung once said, ‘Until you make the unconscious conscious, it will direct your life and you will call it fate.’ This quote captures why I’m so fascinated by discussions about nature and nurture. And why I want you to be too—particularly when it comes to your finances, so that you can start making conscious financial decisions.

What do I mean by nature and nurture? I want to make it very clear that I’m not a scientist, so I’ve no doubt taken liberties throughout this book. But as far as my definition of Financial Phenotype is concerned, here’s what I mean by nature and nurture.

Nature is the more unchangeable part of who we are. It’s the genetic code we received from our parents and is observed as everything from our eye colour to our height to our personality type and more. While it can still be changed or altered, it’s generally more fixed. Whereas nurture is the impact of our environment on who we are—this includes everything from our upbringing, our environment, our culture, our life experiences and more.

Examining this interplay of nature and nurture when it comes to money helps us develop a keen understanding around our financial behaviours. It can help explain why we’re predisposed to act a certain way when presented with particular triggers and stressors, or why we thrive in certain situations or as the result of certain experiences while other people flail (or vice versa).